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BOTH BNP AND JAMAAT WILL NOW HAVE TO CONTEND WITH THE AMBITIONS OF STUDENT LEADERS WHO ARE FORMING THEIR OWN POLITICAL PARTY



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A COUNTRY IN TURMOIL
Clockwise from far left, foreign secretary Vikram Misri (right) with Bangladeshi counterpart Md Jashim Uddin in Dhaka, Dec. 9; Crowds at Sheikh Hasina's office after her ouster, Aug. 5; Hasina waits to cast her vote, Jan. 7, 2024

and the crucial Bay of Bengal, the US apparently began pressuring Dhaka to allow it to use the tiny St Martin's Island, situated just 8 km from Myanmar, as a military base. Experts believe they wanted to maintain it as a surveillance post for Chinese and Myanmar activities and for the strategic Malacca Straits. Ahead of the January general election, Hasina had claimed that a "white man" had offered her a smooth return as PM if she sanctioned the military base. Later, at a press conference, she said, "I don't want to return to power by leasing out St Martin's." The US has denied both its interest in St Martin's or any deal for it. However, on a parallel track, several US-based multinational oil and gas corporations such as Chevron and Exxon Mobil had considered participating in the bidding for prospecting and leasing offshore oil and gas blocks offered by the government-owned oil company Petrobangla. The projects are worth several billion dollars, and this was said to be of great commercial interest, with sources close to Hasina claiming that the US was putting pressure on her to sign the deal.

Indian experts believe that the Deep State in the US may have had a hand in ousting Hasina. The military and commercial motivations were attractive enough. It helped that she was violating all tenets of democracy. Yunus is seen to be close to the US as he had taken refuge there after Hasina charged him of embezzling funds from the Grameen Telecom. India thus needs to negotiate this minefield of competing interests deftly to ensure its relations with Bangladesh remain strong, its core interests protected and the Hindu community there is not persecuted.

YUNUS'S CROWN OF THORNS

Yunus, though, brushes away charges that religious intolerance and extremism are growing in Bangladesh. In press interviews, the chief advisor points to his cabinet which he claims is packed with human rights activists and pluralists. But the tide of exuberance that greeted his assuming the reins of the interim government in August, when people and the students who led the uprising united, now seems to have receded. There is growing concern on whether the well-meaning Yunus is in charge or just a velvet glove for the iron fist of radicalised student leaders and parties working with the Bangladesh Army to launch sweeping constitutional and ideological changes in the country.

Veena Sikri, another former Indian high commissioner to Bangladesh, remains highly critical of the new dispensation. "The chief advisor is unable to take decisions or unable to implement them," she says. "It is now the Islamists who oversee this unconstitutional government as the current Constitution has no provision for such an interim government." As proof of the new regime's excesses, she points to how the chief justice of the Bangladesh Supreme Court, Obaidul Hassan, and five other justices were forced to resign under duress soon after Hasina's ouster. The student leaders have not only gone ahead with their plans to restructure the country's judiciary but are